



Véla

VÉLA RECOVERY BRIEFS · NO. 002

Eating Across Time Zones

By crew, for crew.

VELAFORCREW.COM

Cruising altitude. Meal service done.

And your stomach still doesn't know what time it thinks it is.

Bloating. Cramping. No appetite, or too much of it.

Not because something's wrong with you.

Because your gut is trying to run on a schedule nobody told it about.

WHY THIS WORKS

Your gut runs on its own internal clock, influenced by when you eat. Your brain runs on a separate clock, set mainly by light.¹ Cross time zones while your meal schedule keeps shifting, and the two can stop working together. When that happens, digestion can suffer — showing up as bloating, irregular bowel habits, and other gut symptoms.^{2,3}

We asked 93 crew about their body clock. 71% said they've never really thought about it, or don't track it at all.⁴ The gut clock is usually the last thing on that list — even though it's often the first thing to complain.

What the Research Shows

- A 2026 review of shift work in airline pilots and cabin crew found significantly higher rates of indigestion, IBS-like symptoms, and constipation compared to day workers — with the strongest effects in long-haul and night operations.⁵
- The same review found that half of respondents had limited access to nutritious food while on duty.⁵

What the Evidence Points To

- Studies link heavy, sugary meals eaten during your body's normal sleep hours with more digestive problems and a gut thrown out of balance — the same meals, eaten during your body's daytime hours, cause less disruption.^{8,9}
- Late, heavy meals in particular are linked to a disrupted gut and a slower-running metabolism — regardless of how much you eat across the whole day.⁹
- Fibre-rich foods may also support the gut clock. As gut bacteria break fibre down, they produce compounds that can influence the internal clocks running in your body's tissues — including your gut's — based on early research in animal studies.¹⁰

Putting It Into Practice

ON DAYS OFF

- Keep your meal times fixed, even with nothing to plan around.

A day off with no fixed mealtimes is one of the easiest ways to lose the alignment you built on your last trip.¹

- The day before report is day one of the trip.

If your next report is unusually early or late, shift your meal times toward it a day ahead — don't adjust cold on report morning.

IN FLIGHT

- Pick one clock — origin or destination — and stick to it.

Longer stays: sync to destination. Short turnarounds: stay closer to origin. The important part is choosing deliberately — not eating simply because service happens to arrive.²

- Treat the overnight meal as optional for your gut.

A full meal at a time your body still reads as the middle of the night works against the reset, not for it.^{2,3}

- Pair meals with light — window shade up or down.

The two signals reinforce each other rather than working separately.¹

ON LAYOVER

- Eat on destination time from your first meal — don't wait for appetite.

Realigning meal timing to your destination is one of the more effective ways to help your gut clock catch up alongside the rest of your body.^{6,7}

- Short layover? Don't fully re-anchor.

If you're turning back before your body would've adjusted anyway, staying closer to origin timing means less whiplash on the way home.

EXAMPLE

Home Base → Sydney. You land at 07:00 local — your body still thinks it's 23:00. Rather than waiting for your appetite to catch up, the first meal on the ground goes on Sydney time. That's the "commit early" point above, put into practice.

→ CREW NOTE

None of this fully resolves on a job built around irregular hours. The goal isn't a perfect gut. It's fewer bad days.

Sources

This brief draws on peer-reviewed research and Véla's own crew survey (n=93, 2026). Full citations below for anyone who wants to read further.

1. Chrononutrition and Gut Health: Exploring the Relationship Between Meal Timing and the Gut Microbiome. *PubMed*, 2025.
2. Circadian rhythms, gut microbiota, and diet: possible implications for health. *Nutrition, Metabolism & Cardiovascular Diseases*, 2023.
3. Meal timing is a critical factor for maintenance of gut homeostasis around the clock. *bioRxiv*, 2025.
4. Véla crew survey, n=93, 2026.
5. Health Implications of Shift Work in Airline Pilots and Cabin Crew: A Narrative Review and Pilot Study Findings. *MDPI Nutrients*, 2025.
6. Circadian rhythm and the gut microbiome: a synchrony to the metabolic response to diet. *The Egyptian Journal of Internal Medicine*, 2026.
7. Unraveling the Impact of Travel on Circadian Rhythm and Crafting Optimal Management Approaches: A Systematic Review. *Cureus / PMC*, 2026.
8. Circadian Disorganization Alters Intestinal Microbiota. *PLOS One*, 2014.
9. Shift work, gut dysbiosis, and circadian misalignment: the combined impact of nighttime light exposure, nutrients, and microbiota rhythmicity. *Chronobiology International*, 2025.
10. Gut Microbiota-Derived Short Chain Fatty Acids Induce Circadian Clock Entrainment in Mouse Peripheral Tissue. *Scientific Reports*, 2018.

*Your gut doesn't reset when you land.
It resets when you eat like you mean it.*

This is one brief. Your roster changes every few days.
That's where Véla comes in.

Inside Véla, your meal timing guidance updates
automatically with your roster, so your gut isn't the last
thing anyone thinks about.

Sincerely,

A crew member who got tired of being tired

★ VÉLA

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